Little Lab Coats

🌍 Earth Day Recycling Sort & Earth Helper Pledge 🌿

A free Grade 2/3 Earth Day mini-lesson for celebrating, sorting, and helping the planet

📚 **Grades:** 2nd–3rd ⏱️ **Time:** 35–45 minutes 🧰 **Prep:** Print, cut item cards if desired

🎁 **Format:** Free printable lesson + worksheet + answer key

Gemini-generated artwork for this free Earth Day lesson

Big idea: Earth Day reminds us that small choices matter. When kids learn how to sort waste, reuse what they can, and care for shared spaces, they become real helpers for the planet right now — not just someday.

🎯 What kids will do

- Sort common items into **recycle**, **compost**, or **trash**.

- Talk about why some choices help the Earth more than others.
- Choose one realistic action they can take this week as an **Earth Helper**.

📦 Materials

- Printed worksheet pages
- Scissors (optional)
- Glue stick or tape (optional)
- Crayons, markers, or colored pencils

👩‍🏫 Quick prep

- Decide whether students will **draw lines** to the bins or **cut and sort** the cards.
- Remind students that **recycling rules vary by town**.
- For this lesson, sort by the **most common classroom-friendly rule of thumb**.

Teacher note: This is a celebration lesson, not a local recycling-law lesson. If your city handles an item differently, just tell students: “Good scientists check local rules too.”

🌱 Warm-up: What does it mean to help Earth?

Step 1 — Notice (3–5 min): Show the hero picture. Ask: “What are these kids doing that helps the planet?”

Step 2 — Think (3 min): Ask: “What happens when things that could be reused or recycled get thrown away?”

Step 3 — Share (3–5 min): Invite a few quick ideas: save water, pick up litter, recycle paper, reuse bags, walk instead of driving, plant flowers for pollinators.

♻️ Mini teach: Three smart sorting choices

♻️ Recycle

Items made from paper, cardboard, metal, or some plastics can sometimes become new things again.

paper **cardboard** **clean cans** **clean bottles**

🍌 Compost

Fruit and plant scraps can break down and help make healthy soil.

banana peel **apple core** **plant scraps** **leaves**

🗑️ Trash

Some things cannot be recycled or composted in a simple home/classroom system.

- **chip bag**
- **broken crayon**
- **old sock**
- **greasy paper**

Helpful script: “Before we throw something away, we can ask: Can this be used again? Can it be recycled? Can it turn into soil? If not, then it probably goes in the trash.”

🧪 Activity: Sort it out!

Step 1: Read each item card together.

Step 2: Students sort it into recycle, compost, or trash.

Step 3: For any tricky item, ask: “Why did you choose that?”

Step 4: Wrap up by choosing one Earth Helper promise for the week.

✂️ Student Worksheet — Earth Day Sort

Name: Date:

Directions: Cut out the cards or point and sort. Put each item in the best bin: **Recycle**, **Compost**, or **Trash**.

♻️ Recycle

Can this material become something new again?

🍎 Compost

Can it break down and help make soil?

🗑️ Trash

If it does not fit the other two bins, it goes here.

Item cards

- 📰 **newspaper**
- 📦 **cereal box**
- 🥫 **aluminum can**
- 🧴 **plastic bottle**
- 🍌 **banana peel**
- 🍎 **apple core**
- 🫙 **glass jar**
- 🛍️ **paper bag**
- 🧦 **old sock**
- 🖍️ **broken crayon**
- 🍕 **greasy pizza box**
- 🥔 **chip bag**

💚 My Earth Helper Pledge

I can help the planet in small, real ways. This week I promise to:

_____

_____

Why this helps Earth:

_____

_____

Signed: _____

👩‍🏫 Parent / Teacher Answer Key

Sorting key for this printable:

- **Recycle:** newspaper, cereal box, aluminum can, plastic bottle, glass jar, paper bag
- **Compost:** banana peel, apple core
- **Trash:** old sock, broken crayon, greasy pizza box, chip bag

Good discussion questions

- Why is a **greasy** pizza box different from a clean cardboard box?
- Why is it smart to rinse containers before recycling them?
- What is one thing at home you could reuse instead of throwing away?

What success looks like

- Student correctly sorts most items.
- Student can explain at least one choice.
- Student chooses one realistic Earth Helper action they can actually do.

🌼 Easy extension ideas

Neighborhood helper walk

Bring a glove and bag and pick up a few safe pieces of litter with an adult.

Reuse challenge

Find one container at home that can be reused instead of tossed.

Water saver

Turn off the tap while brushing teeth and report back how it felt.

Pollinator kindness

Plant or notice one flower that helps bees or butterflies.

Made for Little Lab Coats • Free Earth Day printable • Artwork generated with Gemini and lesson assembled for print-friendly home use